FIRE ‘n ICE

BEFORE / RECONSTRUCTED EARLIER DIRECTION

Prepared from the original story overview and Tobi’s retrospective account of the earlier ball-sacrifice direction. This is a reconstructed comparison version, not an untouched historical draft.

01. The Great Lie of the E.C.I.

We open in Las Mareas at its peak. ECI officers start off as normalised (part of the scenery) and are framed as righteous protectors. The city feels complete and wholesome rather than divided and oppressive.

The lie. One that we as the player will spend the game peeling away.

Xiara, the protagonist, lives comfortably inside that belief. She has routines. She has structure. She has people. As long as those remain intact, the illusion holds. She isn’t aware of what’s happening under the surface just yet, and when she does, will she be willing to fully believe?

02. Everyday Life

Xiara’s internal conflict mirrors the city’s philosophy. Her parents push her toward robotics and interests that are more practical and/or respectable. But to them, sports (basketball) and activities like street art are treated as childish distractions that would make her look like “riff-raff” in a world that basically prides itself on being obsessed with fitting a mold.

An argument breaks out. It ends with Xiara storming off, feeling boxed in by the people who raised her to believe this city was built on care.

Her uncle, however, is different. He never asks her to change herself. Instead, he encourages the messier parts of who she is. He’s her anchor.

03. The First Crack

Still raw from the argument, Xiara goes to see her uncle, looking for grounding and reassurance that she isn’t wrong for feeling trapped.

To her shock, she finds his apartment destroyed. Shattered glass, overturned furniture and her uncle gone, with no signs of a hasty departure on his end.

This cracks the illusion. An innocent man has been taken, and the city absorbs it without pause. Life goes on, without so much as a protest.

Xiara’s anger evolves into terror at the realisation that when her anchor is removed, there is nothing in the city designed to catch her. For the first time, the beauty of Las Mareas feels insulting.

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04. The Voice

In the aftermath, she hears a voice. It draws her to her magnetic basketball, one of her previous robotics projects that she left in her uncle’s apartment during her last visit to show him.

Xiara resents it immediately. She only built it to keep scores. Yet, the ball seems to know things. Mainly routes to places that the city tries to hide or doesn’t want her or anyone else to go.

05. The Filter

Following the ball leads Xiara to a hidden generator. When she destroys it, the city visibly changes. It feels less… comfortable. What’s revealed underneath isn’t the truth that the city is ruined, but how it was never fixed to begin with.

Las Mareas isn’t just designed, it’s literally filtered.

But why?

06. Learning What ECI Really Is

As Xiara pushes deeper, she notices something unsettling about ECI officers. Their perception doesn’t change when generators fall. Their equipment, mainly the tanks mounted to their backs, filters the air, keeping them immune to the hallucination gas shaping the city’s appearance.

ECI knows the truth. They always have. The system is built on separation.

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07. A Movement With No Motion

Xiara begins to uncover traces of resistance (graffiti tags, etc.?). People knew something was wrong. They just never pushed far enough to get out of their comfort zone. They failed because the illusion worked too well, not because ECI’s opposition was too great.

Further, she learns that ECI didn’t crush the resistance through violence, but rather let it dissolve by keeping people isolated and unsure of who they could trust.

This puts Xiara in the driver’s seat, where she’s now rebooting the resistance.

As they move through the city, Xiara begins to bond with the ball she initially resented.

08. The Twist

Later in the game, Xiara uncovers the truth that hurts the most. Her parents supported ECI.

Mainly out of fear. They wanted safety and wanted order. They wanted a city that promised their daughter a future, a real and stable future, even if that required others who didn’t fit ECI’s mold to be quietly pushed aside.

They believed stability was more important than solidarity.

This is when Xiara understands that ECI is not an occupying force but rather a reflection of collective and weaponised fear.

09. Purpose

Xiara learns that it was her uncle who embedded a compass, a map and failsafe into the basketball while it was in his possession. He anticipated what ECI would do… punish connection.

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10. The City Strikes Back

As more generators fall, the illusion weakens citywide. NPCs react differently. Some thank Xiara, some panic and some may even report her. ECI escalates, making navigating the city and avoiding ECI more difficult. Fighting back now becomes mandatory to press on.

11. ECI

The final generator lies at the heart of ECI’s operation, where her uncle is being held. There, the truth is clear.

ECI was never temporary. The initiative was a test to see whether a city could be stabilised by breaking its community and bonds.

The city doesn’t maintain harmony by supporting its people, but rather by filtering what they are allowed to perceive.

It worked. Until one connection mattered too much to remove cleanly. Xiara’s and her uncle’s.

To destroy the last generator, Xiara must sacrifice the ball she has grown to care about.

12. Ending

With the generators destroyed, Las Mareas stands exposed.

The ball is destroyed in that final sacrifice.

Xiara comes out of this changed. She no longer sees her passions as competing forces. And now, she has a new ambition… to help rebuild her home from the ground up.

Earlier direction: Xiara initially resents the ball, bonds with it during the journey, and ultimately sacrifices it to destroy the final generator. The original overview’s broad ambition to rebuild Las Mareas is retained; no completed rebuilding is added.